

No need here for a biographical profile of the principal author of *Security Analysis*: Graham's own memoir delightfully covers that ground. Suffice it to say that the high school brainiac entered Columbia College as an Alumni Scholar in September 1911 at the age of 17. So much material had he already absorbed that he began with a semester's head start, "the highest possible advanced standing."¹⁷ He graduated number 2 in the class of 1914 and followed up his Phi Beta Kappa performance by writing a paper suggesting improvements in the teaching of calculus that *The American Mathematical Monthly* saw fit to publish.¹⁸

From these academic heights, Graham descended to the ground floor of Wall Street, beginning his career as a runner and board-boy at the New York Stock Exchange member firm of Newburger, Henderson & Loeb. Within a year, the trainee was playing the liquidation of the Guggenheim Exploration Company by astutely going long the shares of Guggenheim and short the stocks of the companies in which Guggenheim had made a minority investment, as his no-doubt bemused elders looked on: "The profit was realized exactly as calculated; and everyone was happy, not least myself."¹⁹

His masterwork, *Security Analysis*, did not come out of the blue. Long before he began teaching the advanced securities analysis course at Columbia University, in 1928 (with the assistance of David Dodd, his future *Security Analysis* collaborator), Graham had supplemented his income by contributing articles to the *Magazine of Wall Street*. His productions are unmistakably those of a self-assured and superbly educated Wall Street moneymaker. There was no need to quote expert opinion. He and the documents he interpreted were all the authority he needed. His favorite topics were the ones that he subsequently

¹⁷ *The Memoirs of the Dean of Wall Street*, p. 106.

¹⁸ Benjamin Graham, "Some Calculus Suggestions by a Student," *American Mathematical Monthly*, June 1917, vol. 24, no. 6, pp. 265–71.